her husband that sparked the thought of coaxing Ziro's bumper crop of kiwi, which often rotted unsold, into something more valuable—and potable. She had grown up surrounded by apple orchards, plum trees and pear groves in her parents' home in Biiri, a small village in Ziro Valley. "The fruits in our orchard often lay fallen and rotting, a lasting, painful memory that shaped my view of farming," says Rita.

In 2016, she took a Rs 4 crore loan and sank her savings into a winery she called Naara-Aaba, where *naara* stands for place or clan, and *aaba* means father. The gamble meant debt, risk and loss of steady income. She hired a highly skilled professional vintner to make wine from the subtropical kiwi varieties grown at 5,000 ft. "A winery is only a food processing unit that preserves the goodness of a fruit in the form of wine," she says. "Our wine is a story of abundance, necessity, and scarcity too."

For a small-scale entrepreneur in India's alco-bev sector, the difficulties are manifold. Unlike grape wines that benefit from established supply chains and centuries of technical knowledge, Rita had to engineer every aspect of production from scratch. For instance, her bottles, initially imported from Sichuan in China via Mumbai and Kolkata, often cost more in freight than the fruit inside. When bottle imports proved prohibitive, she negotiated supplies from Hyderabad, accepting higher breakage rates as a cost of doing business. Each bottle now costs Rs 46–48, including GST and transportation. "The alcobeverage sector is startup-unfriendly, and I strongly advocate policy reforms to make it more inclusive for grassroots and first-generation entrepreneurs," says Rita.

Despite the odds, Naara-Aaba has grown into a 60,000-litre capacity winery, producing not only kiwi wine but also plum and pear vintages.



VIN DE ZIRO Tage Rita at the winery

> **"WE ARE ONLY A FOOD PROCESSING UNIT THAT PRESERVES THE GOODNESS OF THE FRUIT IN THE FORM OF A WINE. OUR WINE IS A STORY OF ABUNDANCE, NECESSITY AND SCARCITY TOO"**
>
> **TAGE RITA TAKHE**

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Naara-Aaba

What they do: Make wine out of kiwi fruit

Founded in: 2017

Annual turnover
Rs 50 crore

Rita built a decentralised supply chain, buying from her own three-hectare orchard and a cooperative of local farmers. Employment has multiplied. Local dropouts find work in orchards and at the winery; young men and women are engaged during harvest and processing. Wine tourism has followed. Ziro Valley, already a magnet for travellers, now offers tastings and tours. Rita hopes to make Ziro a wine tourism hub that can even outmatch, say, Nashik in Maharashtra, thanks to its distinctive landscape and a culture that lives in harmony with nature.

Awards have followed too. The Women Transforming India Award from NITI Aayog and the UN in 2018. The Nari Shakti Puraskar, India's highest civilian honour for women, in 2022. The same year, she was invited by the US Department of State to join the prestigious Fortune–Global Women's Mentoring Partnership, as one of just 15 women selected worldwide. Last year, the Indian embassy in Taipei placed a consignment order, choosing her winery over hundreds of other competitors as a showcase of Indian innovation.

Yet, the significance of Rita's feats lies less in accolades than in proof of concept. She has demonstrated that small-scale agribusinesses in India's peripheries can leap beyond subsistence farming. By marrying local produce with modern branding, she has created value chains that sustain communities and appeal to global markets. ■